

The Red and the Black

Colombia, Stendhal, and the Price of Arriving Too Soon

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An aristocracy is entered by initiation, not by acceleration.

1 The eternal finalist

Before Colombia ever frightened the world, Colombian football had already learned, thoroughly and in public, how to lose a final. Deportivo Cali reached the Copa Libertadores final in 1978 and lost it. Then América de Cali, the red devils of the Pacific coast, turned losing finals into a vocation: three consecutive Libertadores finals — 1985, 1986, 1987 — and three defeats, to Argentinos Juniors, to River Plate, to Peñarol, with a fourth final and a fourth defeat waiting in 1996.¹ This was the country of the *almost*: brilliant enough to reach the last step, never hardened enough to climb it. It is the necessary first fact, because a country that has spent a decade losing finals is a country being slowly taught the only lesson football teaches for free — that you pay before you win, and that you pay in defeats.

It should be said once, plainly, and then left alone: this football did not grow in a garden. That América, like much of the Colombian game of those years, was lifted by the era's most profitable and least nameable export, in the most violent decade the country had yet lived. The money built the dazzle. It never built a foundation — which is half of why the dazzle, when it finally came, could not last.

2 The first closure

The closure came in 1989. Atlético Nacional of Medellín became the first Colombian club to win the Copa Libertadores, beating Olimpia of Paraguay over two legs and then a penalty shoot-out that René Higuita dragged the club through with his hands and his nerve.² Maturana on the bench; Higuita in goal; Andrés Escobar at the back; Leonel Álvarez in midfield. It was not only a trophy. It was the moment the country stopped being *almost*, and — this matters — it was the spine of the team that would walk into a World Cup a year later. The national side did not appear from nowhere in 1990. It came out of a decade of lost finals and one victory that finally broke the spell, carrying the dangerous lesson a single triumph teaches a country that has waited too long: that it had arrived.

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¹Deportivo Cali, 1978 Copa Libertadores runners-up; América de Cali lost the finals of 1985 (Argentinos Juniors), 1986 (River Plate), 1987 (Peñarol) and 1996 (River Plate again). RSSSF, Copa Libertadores finals.

²Atlético Nacional 1989: first Colombian winner of the Copa Libertadores, defeating Olimpia (Asunción) and prevailing on penalties; coach Francisco Maturana, in goal René Higuita, in defence Andrés Escobar, in midfield Leonel Álvarez. RSSSF, Copa Libertadores finals.

3 The borrowed orange

Before the yellow, there was orange. Through the early 1980s Colombia played in a strong orange shirt that was, frankly, somebody else's idea: the Netherlands, the Clockwork Orange of Cruyff whose total football the planet was still copying. In Colombia the imitation was teased for what it was — a tropical knock-off, the *Zapote Mecánico*, named for the orange-fleshed fruit.³ A country that would, within the decade, dream of the world's aristocracy was dressing in a borrowed identity.

The break came around 1985, and it was deliberate. The federation wanted an aesthetic revolution — to stop looking like a tropical Holland and dress instead like the flag — and handed the redesign to María Elvira Pardo, a Colombian designer with a Dior pedigree, who built a tricolour logic from yellow, blue and red.⁴ Yellow was not even the certain winner at first: for a time it shared the role of first-choice shirt with a red one — which is precisely why red was still near enough the surface to be the colour Colombia wore in Milan. Yellow won in the end not by decree but by use, memory and sheer visual force. The Italia 1990 shirt — the Pibe's, Higuaita's, Rincón's — was already the golden yellow the world would keep,⁵ and the federation fixed it as the home shirt around the 1992 Barcelona Olympics, Umbro later setting it in stone.

The point is not colour theory. It is that Colombia built its own image at the exact moment its first great modern generation arrived: Nacional champions of a continent in 1989, the national team back at a World Cup in 1990, Valderrama a global icon, Higuaita an anomaly. After 1990 the yellow was no longer a shirt; it was a country finally seeing itself in its own colours. Which is the quiet irony beneath everything that follows — a country that had just learned to stop borrowing an *identity* walked into a World Cup and tried to borrow a *nobility* instead.

4 The red shirt

In Milan, Colombia wore red, and made the future champions wait until stoppage time to escape with a draw.

It had taken twenty-eight years to get there. Colombia's only previous World Cup was Chile 1962; a whole generation had been born, grown up and grown old without seeing the country at the tournament. And it came back through the narrowest door the format allows: finishing the lowest-scoring of South America's three group winners, it was sent to an intercontinental play-off against Israel, settled by a single goal from Albeiro "Palomo" Usuriaga⁶ in Barranquilla and a goalless draw in Ramat Gan — 1–0 on aggregate, two matches, one goal.⁷ A country returned to the world by the width of a single Usuriaga finish.

The detail matters. Not yellow — not yet the colour by which the later myth would dress the memory — but red: the shirt in which that country looked West Germany in the eye and refused to vanish. A few minutes from the end, Pierre "Litti" Littbarski — *Migajita*, "Little Crumb," in the affectionate bestiary of the commentator Andrés Salcedo⁸ — put Germany ahead, and for a

³Football Kit Archive catalogues the 1980 and 1982 Colombia shirts on an orange base (orange/yellow/red).

⁴Per the reconstruction by NSS Sports; the mid-1980s redesign is attributed to María Elvira Pardo.

⁵*The Bogotá Post* describes the 1990 shirt as "golden"; NSS Sports dates the definitive adoption of yellow as the home shirt to around 1992, from the Barcelona Olympics, consolidated afterward under Umbro. Football Kit Archive records yellow as the dominant colour of the modern Colombia home shirt.

⁶*Palomo*: "the Dove."

⁷Colombia's only prior World Cup was Chile 1962; as the lowest-scoring CONMEBOL group winner it contested the intercontinental play-off against Israel (Colombia 1–0, Barranquilla, 15 Oct 1989, Usuriaga; 0–0, Ramat Gan, 30 Oct 1989), 1–0 on aggregate. RSSSF, "World Cup 1990 Qualifying"; "Colombia — World Cup Qualifiers."

⁸For a whole continent the Bundesliga arrived in the voice of one Colombian, Andrés Salcedo, who narrated German football and renamed its players in affectionate Spanish: Littbarski was his *Migajita* ("Little Crumb"), and the menagerie ran to *el Cavernícola* ("the Caveman") and beyond. The footballing culture told itself in

few minutes the old hierarchy held. Germany would lift the cup in Rome three weeks later.

Then Valderrama found Rincón. The pass did not thunder; it slipped. Freddy Rincón ran through the middle and rolled the ball under Bodo Illgner, between the goalkeeper's legs, as if the future champion had briefly forgotten to shut the door.⁹ Colombia had not beaten Germany. It had done something more dangerous: it had drawn with Germany *beautifully*, beautifully enough to believe the draw meant more than a draw.

What anyone who watched that tournament still sees is small and white: the Adidas Etrusco Unico, the ball with the Etruscan lion-heads in its triads, rolling under the sole of Higuaita's boot — the image Italia 1990 left on the retina of a continent.¹⁰

There is a historical hinge buried in that scoreline, and it is worth naming because it doubles the meaning. The side Colombia held in Milan was the last West Germany — not yet the unified Germany. The 1990 World Cup was West Germany's final act under that name; reunification came on 3 October 1990, months after Rome. By the time Germany returned to a World Cup in 1994 it was one country, and it did not even have to qualify, because the title won against Argentina in Rome carried it straight to the United States. Colombia's red-shirt miracle, then, was performed against a footballing state about to disappear into another form — the reigning power at the precise instant before it changed shape.

5 The goalkeeper who mocked his job

René Higuaita was not a goalkeeper with eccentric habits. He was an argument against the job description. He came off his line not as a tactic but as a temperament, carried the ball upfield when a goalkeeper is supposed to hide behind it, and treated the eighteen-yard box as a clerical error he intended to correct in person.

Against Germany, it was funny because it worked. Völler and Klinsmann chased him like men trying to repossess a car from someone who had already sold it twice. For an afternoon the most dangerous strikers alive looked less like predators than creditors, and the absurd became, briefly, a form of mastery.

Four days later, against Cameroon in the second round, the joke received its invoice. Higuaita came out as he always did; Roger Milla — thirty-eight, smiling — took the ball from him and walked it into the empty net, and Colombia went home.¹¹ This is why Higuaita cannot be the hero of the story. He is its symptom. A goalkeeper who cannot wait at his line is a country rehearsing its own impatience: in 1990 the excess still looked like imagination; by 1994 the same national impulse had hardened into doctrine. Colombia had begun to believe it had arrived because one night had been too beautiful.

6 The Stendhalian ascent

Stendhal gives the title its deeper wound. *Le Rouge et le Noir* is not only a matter of colour — the red shirt in Milan, the black that would settle over the story — but of ascent. Julien Sorel, the carpenter's son with a furnace of ambition, wants admission into an aristocracy whose rituals he has not yet survived; he climbs by nerve and seduction and forged credentials, far faster than

nicknames — a commentator's language that made a character of every man before he touched the ball.

⁹West Germany 1–1 Colombia, group stage, Milan, 19 June 1990; Littbarski 88', Rincón 92'. RSSSF, "World Cup 1990 — Final Tournament."

¹⁰The Etrusco Unico belonged to the Adidas "Tango" lineage launched in 1978, which dressed every World Cup ball through the Tricolore of France 1998 and was revived a generation later as the Tango 12 of Euro 2012.

¹¹Cameroon 2–1 Colombia (a.e.t.), round of 16, 23 June 1990; Milla twice, the second off Higuaita's error far upfield. RSSSF, "World Cup 1990."

his station allows, and the speed of the climb is the cause of the fall. He takes the black cassock and dreams the red of Napoleonic glory, and dies at the top of the ladder for having gone up it too fast.

Colombia, in 1994, wanted exactly Julien's thing in football. It did not merely intend to compete. **It tried to enter the aristocracy of world football by acceleration rather than initiation.** The evidence it offered itself was a single night: in qualifying it went to the Monumental in Buenos Aires and beat Argentina 5–0 on Argentina's own grass,¹² a result so total it stopped being a score and became a feeling, and the feeling went straight to the blood of a country. Pelé named Colombia a favourite to win the World Cup. But a thrashing in a qualifier is not a patent of nobility, and the lesson was available next door — in the same language, on the same continent, a short flight away. Brazil had been schooled by the Maracanazo in 1950; Argentina by Cruyff's 4–0 in 1974; each was tempered by its beating before it reigned.¹³ Colombia was the latecomer who would not learn from the houses on its own street, mistaking a 5–0 for the initiation its neighbours had each paid for in humiliation. The thrashing was not payment. It was a receipt for something else.

7 The blue shirt

In the United States, Colombia wore blue exactly once — against Romania, in its opening match — and for that single night the colour change is almost too neat: the red of the miracle put away, the blue of the reckoning taken out for the very game in which it began to go wrong. Gheorghe Hagi — the Maradona of the Carpathians — opened the country up and Romania won that first match. Then the United States, and elimination. Colombia beat Switzerland in the last game, when it was already out: three points against the weakest team in the group, too late to mean anything.¹⁴ Pelé's favourite finished bottom. The aristocracy did not admit the provincial who had arrived without serving his time; it sent him home in the order these things always happen — first the shock, then the proof, then the meaningless consolation.

8 What is not named

Eleven days after the match against the United States, in Medellín, the own goal became something the country has never found a name for. That is all that will be said here. This essay is about arriving too soon, and it will not borrow a grief that belongs to other pages.

9 No changing of the guard

Then came the black, and the black was a desert sixteen years long. After France 1998 — first round again, eliminated by the England of David Beckham's first World Cup goal — Colombia did not appear at a World Cup until 2014. The cause was not a failure of talent. It was a failure of *renewal*: Colombia had one great generation and no machine to build the next.

That distinction is the whole point. The golden generation did not disappear; it aged out abroad, in other people's shirts, while no successor came to take the national one. Óscar Córdoba,

¹²Argentina 0–5 Colombia, World Cup qualifier, Buenos Aires, 5 September 1993. RSSSF, "Colombia — World Cup Qualifiers."

¹³Netherlands 4–0 Argentina, 1974 (champions in 1978); Maracanazo, Uruguay 2–1 Brazil, 1950 final pool. RSSSF.

¹⁴Group A, USA 1994: Romania first, Colombia last (lost 3–1 to Romania, 2–1 to the USA, beat Switzerland 2–0). RSSSF, "World Cup 1994 — Final Tournament."

Jorge “el Patrón” Bermúdez¹⁵ and Mauricio “Chicho” Serna won three Copas Libertadores at Boca; a different Córdoba, Iván — no relation — won Mourinho’s treble at Internazionale; Juan Pablo Ángel scored for Aston Villa, Mario Yepes captained in Paris and Milan.¹⁶ The same names, growing older, winning a continent away — and behind them, for the national team, no one. Brazil and Argentina turn out a fresh generation every four years on a conveyor belt; Colombia produced one dazzling cohort and, when it aged, had nobody to relieve it. A flash is not a factory.

And the proof is the cruellest fact of the desert: the next generation was tested at its root and failed. On 30 January 2000, in Londrina, the under-23 side — the very cohort that should have become the relief — needed only to avoid losing to Brazil by seven goals to reach the Olympics, and lost 9–0.¹⁷ That is not a defeat. It is the sound of a changing of the guard that never came.

10 The only cup

Colombia did win something.

That has to be said, because otherwise the story becomes too neat, too tragic, too pleased with its own darkness. In 2001, at home, Colombia won the Copa América. It won every match, conceded no goals, and beat Mexico 1–0 in Bogotá with a header from Iván Ramiro Córdoba. It is the only senior title the national team owns.¹⁸

But even the triumph arrived with a Colombian complication. Argentina had withdrawn from the tournament, on security grounds. Brazil, the defending champion, lost to Honduras in the quarter-finals. The final was not against Argentina, not against Brazil, not against one of the old houses whose approval had haunted the whole story, but against Mexico. None of this makes the title false. It makes it stranger. It was not an illegitimate title; it was worse, narratively — a legitimate title that did not settle the argument. A country can win a cup, immaculate in the record book, and still feel that the central question has not been answered.

That is why 2024 mattered. Colombia reached another Copa América final, this time against Argentina itself — the house, the lineage, the shirt that had survived the 5–0 in Buenos Aires and gone on to win the Copa in 2021 and the World Cup in 2022, with Messi. This time there was no missing aristocrat, no weakened bracket to explain away. The monster was present. Colombia lost in extra time.¹⁹ So the only cup hangs suspended between pride and discomfort — not an asterisk, but an unfinished sentence. The country did lift a trophy. It simply never lifted the one that would have silenced the old question, which is the most Colombian outcome imaginable: to win, and to remain the country of the *almost* anyway.

11 The emeritus

In the Roman legions a soldier who had served his full term and earned his discharge was sometimes kept on for one last appearance — the *miles emeritus*, the veteran who takes the field not because the battle needs him but because honour does. On 24 June 2014, in Cuiabá, with

¹⁵*El Patrón*: “the Boss.”

¹⁶Boca Juniors under Bianchi: Copa Libertadores 2000, 2001, 2003. Iván Córdoba: 2010 treble with Internazionale. RSSSF.

¹⁷Brazil 9–0 Colombia, pre-Olympic (U-23) tournament, Londrina, 30 Jan 2000; Chile qualified for Sydney on the result and won bronze. RSSSF, CONMEBOL Olympic qualifying 2000.

¹⁸Copa América 2001, hosted by Colombia: champion without conceding a goal, beating Mexico 1–0 in the final (Iván Ramiro Córdoba) at El Campín, Bogotá. CONMEBOL, official.

¹⁹Colombia’s Copa América finals: lost to Peru (1975), beat Mexico (2001), lost to Argentina (2024, a.e.t.). The only one without a great rival on the other side is the one Colombia won.

Colombia already through and beating Japan 3–1, José Pekerman sent Faryd Mondragón on in the eighty-fifth minute. He was forty-three, and he wept.

The number people reach for is the age: that night Mondragón was the oldest man ever to play at a World Cup — a mark he held until 2018, when the Egyptian goalkeeper Essam El-Hadary, at forty-five, took it.²⁰ But the record that belongs to this essay is the other one, the one he still holds: sixteen years between his World Cup appearances, 1998 to 2014 — the longest interval in the tournament’s history, and the exact length of the desert.²¹ Because Mondragón is the man who connects the two ends. He was in the 1994 squad, a substitute who never played, present for the fall. He was the starting goalkeeper in 1998, on the field for the elimination that opened the desert. And here he was in 2014, an old soldier sent on for honour, closing with his own body the parenthesis his own generation had opened. Higuaita was the symptom — the impatience that could not wait. Mondragón is the symbol: the soldier who was there when it broke, there when it stayed broken, and there to certify, in person, that the crossing was over. The emeritus does not change the result. He testifies that the war has ended.

12 The children who were watching

He did not enter alone into history; he handed it over. The night Mondragón replaced him in goal, the man he relieved was David Ospina, who had been five years old in 1994. Somewhere in the same generation were James Rodríguez, two years old when the favourite went down, and Juan Cuadrado, six — children who had watched the end without understanding it, and to whom, without anyone deciding it, the return would belong. In 2014 James won the Golden Boot. The old soldier came off the field and left the goal to the boys who had been watching when it broke.

And here the counting stops, which is where Stendhal stops too. One can measure the years of an absence, the goals of a humiliation, the trophies won in other countries’ colours, the age of a goalkeeper sent on for honour. What cannot be measured is whether arriving on time, now, every cycle, is worth what the desert cost — because the old way, the way of the long crossing, made the return ache with a glory that punctuality can never give. Julien Sorel, at the end, refuses to repent: he decides the climb, fatal as it was, was the only life worth having had. Whether Colombia would trade its red shirt and its sixteen black years for a quieter, steadier history is the one question in all of this with no answer in the record book. It is left open, in red and in black, which is the most honest thing the subject allows.

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²⁰Faryd Mondragón, Brazil 2014: oldest player at a World Cup (43) until Essam El-Hadary (Egypt, 45) in 2018.

²¹Mondragón keeps the record for the longest gap between World Cup appearances: sixteen years, 1998→2014. FIFA, “Behind the World Cup record: Faryd Mondragón.”

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